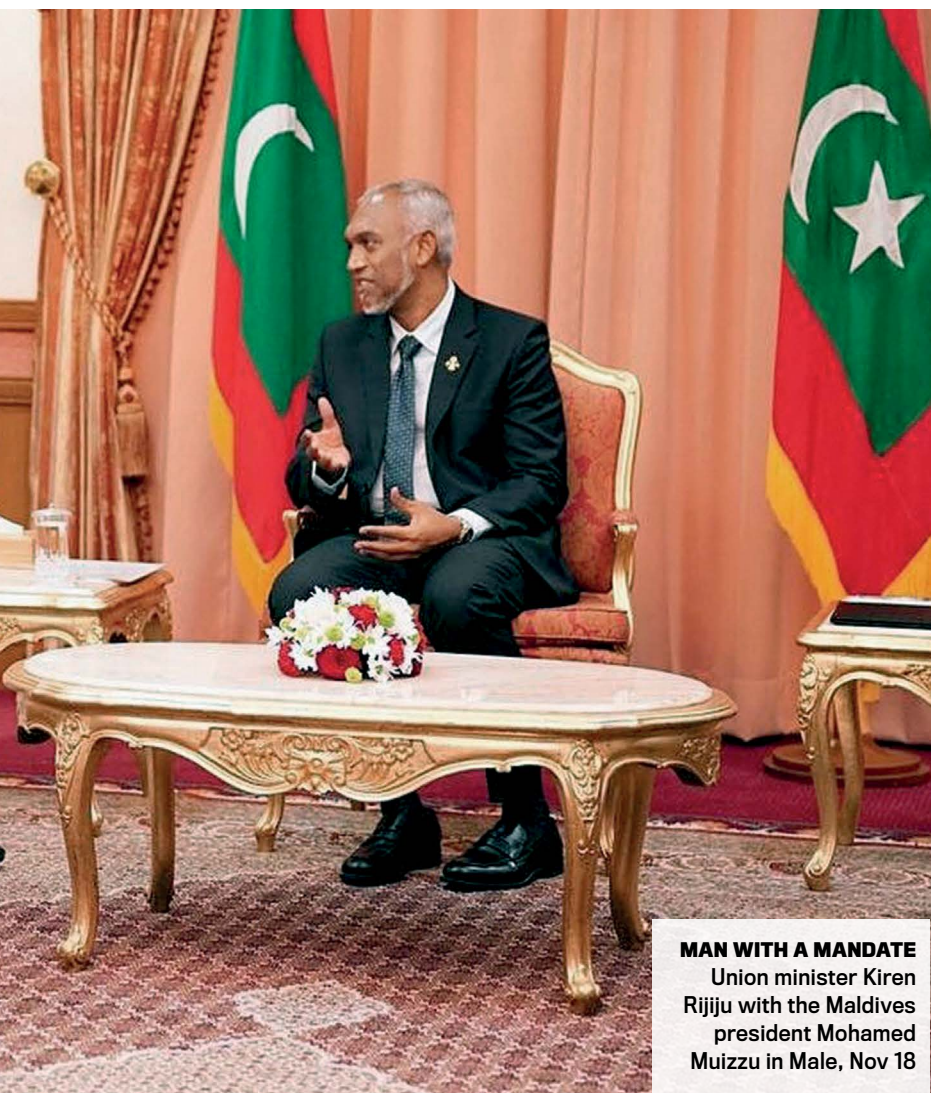
earth sciences minister Kiren Rijiju at the swearing-in on November 17. The downgraded representation is seen as a message to the new Maldivian regime.

When meeting Rijiju on November 18, Muizzu stuck to his guns—a formal request was made to India to withdraw its military personnel from the Maldives. New Delhi has said that both sides will try to find a "workable solution". Muizzu is currently discussing the matter with Indian authorities before arriving on his maiden visit to New Delhi in the last week of November. The bogey of Indian troops "harming the sovereignty of the Maldives" raised by Muizzu—and which he used to defeat Solih of the Maldivian Democratic Party, known for his 'India First' political stand—relates to around 70 Indian military personnel who maintain and operate New Delhi-sponsored radar stations and surveillance aircraft in the Maldives, especially the Dornier aircraft and two Dhruv helicopters gifted by India in the past decade. This minuscule presence has been projected as a security threat and interpreted as the establishment of an Indian military base by the Muizzu faction. However, while bringing up the topic with Rijiju, Muizzu acknowledged the contribution of the helicopters and the aircraft for the medical evacuation of Maldivian citizens.

Situated in the central Indian Ocean, barely 70 nautical miles from Minicoy in Lakshadweep and around 300 nautical miles from India's west coast, and straddling the commercial sea lanes from east and west, the island-nation has great strategic importance for India, which has had close ties with Male. Muizzu's 'India Out' stand, thus, is a setback for India in its geopolitical contest with China—a recent entrant in Male's scheme of things—that is playing out in the Indian Ocean.

Ever since Maldives' transition to a multi-party democracy in 2008, New Delhi-Male ties have gone through highs and lows under the looming shadow of Beijing. Mohamed Nasheed's presidency (2008-2012) affirmed Maldives' time-tested 'India First' policy. Under Mohamed Waheed's presidency (2012-2013), the Maldives cancelled Indian firm GMR's contract for the construction of the Male airport in 2012 and started courting China. The archipelago moved further into China's ambit during the regime of Nasheed's successor, Abdulla Yameen (2013-2018), joining the Chinese president Xi Jinping's Belt and Road Initiative, striking infrastructure deals with China and signing a free trade agreement with it. Significantly, though, India kept up its programme of aid for the Maldives. It ranged from providing defence platforms and installations to humanitar-



**MAN WITH A MANDATE** Union minister Kiren Rijiju with the Maldives president Mohamed Muizzu in Male, Nov 18

